drank alcohol in excess. The British despised the Tiyan subcaste for its ‘considerable laxity of sexual intercourse’. The women of the Bind subcaste, a prudish colonial ethnographer noted, ‘get drunk, dance, sing obscene songs, and indulge in rude debauchery’.[36] British data collection was usually mediated by Brahminical elites, who too historically looked down on the Mallahs. To the Victorian-era British, these were adequate grounds to see the Mallahs as unruly, criminal and depraved, and in need of discipline and reform.

The Mallahs, who the state classifies among the Most Backward Classes for its affirmative action programmes, have tried raising their marginalized social status by associating with the famous *kevat*, or boatman, of the Ramayana. Once during their exile, Rama and Sita arrived at the Sarayu River. They met a kevat from the non-Aryan tribe of Nishads. The kevat honoured them by washing their feet and ferried them across the river. When Sita offered him her ring as payment for his labour, the kevat cleverly declined, saying that people of the same profession do not charge each other for their labour. Rama and Sita were puzzled, so the kevat explained that he ferried people from one shore to the other, similar to the lord ferrying people across the ocean of samsara. The kevat then asked Rama for passage across this ocean, i.e., moksha, which Rama generously granted him.